

Psalms 4

Peaceful Sleep

I will both lay me down in peace, and sleep
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Hear me when I call, O God of my righteousness: thou hast enlarged me when I was in distress; have mercy upon me, and hear my prayer.*
- 2 *O ye sons of men, how long will ye turn my glory into shame? how long will ye love vanity, and seek after leasing? Selah.*
- 3 *But know that the LORD hath set apart him that is godly for himself: the LORD will hear when I call unto him.*
- 4 *Stand in awe, and sin not: commune with your own heart upon your bed, and be still. Selah.*
- 5 *Offer the sacrifices of righteousness, and put your trust in the LORD.*
- 6 *There be many that say, Who will shew us any good? LORD, lift thou up the light of thy countenance upon us.*
- 7 *Thou hast put gladness in my heart, more than in the time that their corn and their wine increased.*
- 8 *I will both lay me down in peace, and sleep: for thou, LORD, only makest me dwell in safety.*

2 · CONTEXT

An evening psalm of David (paired in use with morning Psalm 3). It addresses God, then opponents who shame what is honorable and chase vanity and lies, then returns to trust that yields peace deeper than prosperity. Henry highlights the contrast between many who ask “Who will shew us any good?” and the one who seeks God’s face.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1

Opening plea to the “God of my righteousness,” recalling past enlargement in distress. Mercy and hearing are requested on the basis of God’s proven faithfulness.

Verse 2-3

Rebuke to “sons of men”: how long will they shame glory, love vanity, seek lies? Yet the Lord has set apart the godly for Himself and will hear. Identity under attack is answered by God’s claim on His own.

Verse 4-5

Counsel: stand in awe, sin not; commune with your heart on your bed and be still; offer right sacrifices; trust the Lord. Inner stillness and righteous worship replace restless scheming.

Verse 6-8

Many chase a vague “good”; the psalmist seeks the light of God’s countenance. Gladness exceeds harvest joy. Result: lying down in peace and safety—the Lord alone makes him dwell secure.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

True good is not first more corn and wine but God’s favorable presence. Those set apart by the Lord can be still, trust, and sleep—even when shamed by others—because safety is God’s gift.

Application for life today.

Evening is when vanity and anxiety often win. Before sleep, practice verse 4: quiet heart-communion, not endless scrolling. Measure “good” by God’s face more than by metrics of success. Where shame or false narratives press you, remember you are set apart for God, not defined by mockers.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What “vanity” or false “good” most competes with seeking God’s face right now?

2. How can you practice “be still” on your bed this week without numbing out?

3. Where do you need the peace of verse 8 more than an increase of “corn and wine”?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).